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There is, in fact, a rational reason to favor what look like irrational decisions.

Here's one: Let me suggest that you love your investments.

This is not traditional advice. It's almost a badge of honor for investors to claim they're emotionless about their investments, because it seems rational.

But if lacking emotions about your strategy or the stocks you own increases the odds you'll walk away from them when they become difficult, what looks like rational thinking becomes a liability. The reasonable investors who love their technically imperfect strategies have an edge, because they're more likely to stick with those strategies.

There are few financial variables more correlated to performance than commitment to a strategy during its lean years—both the amount of performance and the odds of capturing it over a given period of time. The historical odds of making money in U.S. markets are 50/50 over one-day periods, 68% in one-year periods, 88% in 10-year periods, and (so far) 100% in 20-year periods. Anything that keeps you in the game has a quantifiable advantage.

If you view “do what you love” as a guide to a happier life, it sounds like empty fortune cookie advice. If you view it as the thing providing the endurance necessary to put the quantifiable odds of success in your favor, you realize it should be the most important part of any financial strategy.

Invest in a promising company you don't care about, and you might enjoy it when everything's going well. But when the tide inevitably turns you're suddenly losing money on something you're not interested in. It's a double burden, and the path of least resistance is to move onto something else. If you're passionate about the company to begin with—you love the mission, the product, the team, the science, whatever—the inevitable down times when you're losing money or the company needs help are blunted by the fact that at least you feel like you're part of something meaningful. That can be the necessary motivation that prevents you from giving up and moving on.